

Ohioview Peninsula

Approximately 30 acres of floodplain forest and a shallow water backchannel area, as well as sections of the river pool above Montgomery Dam comprise this site. The Ohioview Peninsula and its adjacent shallow water embayment and wetlands represent some of the last of such natural features along the Ohio River. It has been recognized by the U.S. Fish and Wildlife Service as the most ecologically significant area on the Pennsylvania portion of the Ohio River (1986). Biological surveys done at this site by the USFWS (1986) and Federal Energy Regulatory Commission (1984) revealed four fish species of concern in the embayment and the pool above the dam. The presence of these fish species suggests that the water quality in this section of the Ohio River is improving. The embayment itself has the potential to be habitat for other species of concern since it is somewhat protected from the deeper, open waters of the river.

Other special habitats exist along the fringes of the peninsula and mainland floodplain where small wetlands have formed in protected areas where the river current has less effect on the shoreline. Trees from the **floodplain forest natural community** hang over the water in both the embayment and river side of the peninsula. Mature silver maple (*Acer saccharinum*) and box elder (*Acer negundo*) trees as well as the rich display of herbaceous species typical of floodplains characterize the terrestrial community on the peninsula. The deep, mesic, alluvial soils support such species as wingstem (*Actinomeris alternifolia*), Turk's cap lily (*Lilium superbum*), green dragon (*Arisaema dracontium*), and violet species (*Viola spp.*).

The trees that overhang the water along the peninsula serve as a nesting site for a bird species of concern in Pennsylvania, the **prothonotary warbler** (*Protonotaria citrea*). This bird prefers nesting along the waters edge and is very sensitive to disturbance.

Threats and Stresses:

Presently, the threats that exist for the natural community and the bird species of concern are the use of the area for recreational purposes and the potential for logging. This site is actively used by fishermen who have driven vehicles onto the peninsula and to the very edge of the embayment causing serious erosion problems along the waters edge. In addition, the overly used site is experiencing habitat destruction due to tree cutting for fire wood, burning of campfires, clearing land for camping and day use, etc. This not only threatens the quality of the natural community, but seriously threatens the prothonotary warbler which requires undisturbed, remote areas for nesting, as well as the many other waterfowl and mammals that depend on the embayment and peninsula for nesting and breeding habitat.

Logging or clearing the peninsula for development would obviously result in the destruction of the floodplain forest and habitat for the bird species of concern. Development of any type on the peninsula or near the embayment would degrade or destroy the natural qualities of this last remaining riverine habitat in Pennsylvania. Threats to the fish species of concern include water pollution, a change in the level of the Montgomery pool, or introduction of game fish species that would directly or indirectly outcompete these special species.

Disturbances resulting from navigational activity such as dock construction, shoreline erosion from the wake created by boats, dredging, etc. appear to be restricted in the near vicinity of the peninsula and embayment since they are part of the safety or restricted zone for the Montgomery Dam. Any of these activities, especially upstream dredging, could be detrimental to the natural qualities of the site. In addition, a change in the water level along the river would be particularly destructive to the Ohioview Peninsula. A drop in water level could empty the embayment in whole or in part and an increase in the water level could put important terrestrial habitat under water. Either situation would be destructive.

Recommendations:

Efforts should be made to protect this site from any further disturbances. The upstream end of the peninsula has been excavated in the past and what remains is an area in which the topsoil has been removed and species such as staghorn sumac (*Rhus radicans*) and tree-of-heaven (*Ailanthus altissima*), plants that are considered weedy pioneer species of extremely disturbed habitats, are growing abundantly. It is recommended that topsoil be replaced and graded so that the original topography of this section of peninsula is restored and the floodplain forest natural community can be encouraged to expand onto this section of the site. Development of any type should be avoided, especially in the more natural sections of the site. Recreational use should be limited to low impact activities such as fishing, hiking, nature study, etc. and any type of motorized vehicle use should be avoided. Construction of a gate at the access points to the peninsula would help to remedy this problem. Mooring along the riverside of the peninsula should be avoided since often times trees are pulled down and erosion results. This is especially important since the nesting site for the bird species of concern could be disturbed by such activity. Any activity that is proposed in the area of the site including areas upstream on the river should be evaluated for its potential threat or impact to the Ohioview Peninsula.